

LSAT Handbook

By Vasily (Vas) S. Levin

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I. Disclosure

A. Purpose and Scope

1. This manual is not intended to serve as a study guide or textbook. It is not exhaustive (see II.A, for preparation methods).

2. This manual is not restrictive. Use it as a core principle on which you build your own way to prepare for and take the LSAT (cross-ref. III.A, for test-taking strategies).
3. This manual requires that you know standard methods used to take this test.
4. This manual will be updated in the future to address questions and provide clarification.

II. Test Preparation

A. Initial Review Process

1. After you take your initial diagnostic test, or any test, or even a section of a test, review it. This review might take you a week (see II.B.2 for detailed question review).
2. It might take 40 minutes to review a single question.
3. You should try to figure out three vital things.
 - a. Why did you pick the wrong answer?
 - b. Why did you not pick the correct answer?
 - c. What can you take away from that question? Focus on how to avoid the same mistake again (cross-ref. II.C, for error patterns).

4. For Logical Reasoning questions, review them individually or in small groups to identify patterns in errors (see IV. Logical Reasoning).

B. Learning Effectiveness

1. The described method is an effective way to learn. It is also an effective way to extract the maximum from every LSAT question you do.
2. The LSAT requires hard work. It is a learnable test. While it is not a test for regurgitation of previous knowledge, taking the LSAT is a skill that you can develop and should develop. The LSAT is not something to fear or approach with nervousness. However, it does demand your full attention.
3. There are exceptions to every rule.
4. There are no tips and tricks. Hard work defines the LSAT. The test measures that hard work.
5. Take practice tests and review them. Review them initially. It might take a couple of weeks for one test (see II.G for study schedules).

C. Study Habits and Duration

1. Studying one hour a day could be enough if you stay consistent.

2. Pick the hour when you are at your best. Treat it like you would pick an hour for a date with a significant other.
3. On the other hand, studying more than three hours a day usually is too much for the brain to process. Give yourself enough rest. You are working out your brain in the LSAT gym.

D. Section-Specific Goals

1. Logical Reasoning is your backbone. Get it to -0 or -1 errors per section. This approach provides your 23 confidence points. It does not matter if you think it is scary (see IV.A, for reading techniques).
2. If you make a mistake, find a more effective way to approach the question type. Eliminate mistakes and redo the section.
3. Check rules by the first full order question. Do “if” questions first. Check for a floater. Check for nice restrictive variables. Separate conditional statements. Turn negative into positive (cross-ref. III.E, for diagramming).

E. Progress and Readiness

1. Writing more at the beginning is great. But with more progress, you will likely find that extra stuff distracts you. Strive to commit things to memory and visualization.

2. Take the test when you are ready.
3. You are ready when your practice tests represent the score you accept.
4. Take the average score from at least five different practice tests to have a better performance indicator.
5. Practice tests are the same as the official test.
6. Plan to take the LSAT at least twice.
7. The LSAT is about how hard you can do high-quality work.
Success is in your hands.

F. Resources and Mindset

1. Do not be afraid to use search in the group, Google, LSAC.org, and read supplementary materials.
2. Do not be afraid of research, reading, or writing. You are a future lawyer. That is what you will do for money.

G. Environment and Routine

1. Choose the best time and place of your day for your study session. Treat it as a date night with a significant other.
 - a. The best time is defined by your biological clock, existing distractions, and other factors.

- b. Your goal is to minimize any factors that can make you not perform to your full ability.
 - c. Sleep and eat well. Make sure you have food and drinks for the breaks.
 - d. Use an environment closest to the real test and exclude distractions. For example, if your test is digital, then use the digital interface to study. Do the same for accommodations.
2. Before you sit down, choose any or all of the following options.
- a. Slow down.
 - b. Relax.
 - c. Take a deep breath.
 - d. Meditate.
3. Choose a study schedule from the following guidelines.
- a. Start now.
 - b. Do one timed section per day, five days a week.
 - c. If you have to study for a long time, do a section and review it the next day.
 - d. Take a two-day break.
 - e. Do five days of one section a day again.
 - f. Take a break for a day.
 - g. Do a full PrepTest. If you don't have time for the full test, consider spreading it over two days.

- h. Repeat.
- i. Study for at most 45 minutes at a time. Try not to exceed two hours a day.

H. Timing and Review Protocols

1. Timed means you set the timer. But after the timer expires, you keep working. This practice trains you to ignore the clock.
2. Your goal is to do as many questions as possible correctly.
3. Start with getting the first 10 questions right on Logical Reasoning and the first Reading Comprehension passage.
4. If your time is 35 minutes:
 - a. After the section, take a five-minute break. Then do a blind review. Review the answers you were unsure about.
 - b. Check for incorrect answers. Try to understand why you chose those. Write down what you need to do to avoid these mistakes in the future.
 - c. Review the explanations. After reviewing the explanations, try the questions again.
 - d. Every mistake is an opportunity to learn from and apply it to future questions.
 - e. Try to remember more efficient solutions. Of course, note what you need to do in the future to avoid making any

mistakes.

- f. For Reading Comprehension, reread the whole passage. But attempt only the questions you got wrong.
 - g. Every mistake is a chance to learn something and apply it to future questions (cross-ref. II.A.3).
- 5. If your time is longer than 35 minutes, simply set the timer to your desired duration and review after a long break or the next day. Do everything else as in II.H.4.
 - 6. If your time is longer than 35 minutes and you score above 165, you can try to do the hardest questions or passages first. You would do questions 20-25, 15-20, 10-15, 5-10, 0-5. Do the comparative passage first (see V.B., for comparative strategies).
 - 7. If your time is longer than 35 minutes and you score above 165, you can try writing down questions for Reading Comprehension before you read the passage to stay more engaged. Extra time makes you lose concentration.

I. Memory and Visualization Techniques

- 1. Use speed-reading short-term memory training techniques. You can just use the text visualization part of it.
 - a. Lie down in a meditative pose, such as the corpse pose in yoga. Make sure there are no distractions. Try to feel all

parts of your body, such as the tips of your fingers or the hair on your head, without moving them. Visualize.

- b. This can be done anywhere: Look at any image around you. Look away and try to recreate it in your mind.
- c. This can be done anywhere: Read any text, or do it on the LSAT. Then close your eyes and try to visualize the exact words. This technique does not improve understanding. But it improves your accuracy.

III. Test-Taking

A. Reading and Engagement

- 1. Read all text slowly and engage with it. The key to being fast is being slow (see IV.A.1, for sentence-by-sentence approach).
- 2. Be very critical. Question the arguments made.
- 3. Predict what could follow, such as what could be properly inferred or what could be a proven conclusion, from the given information.

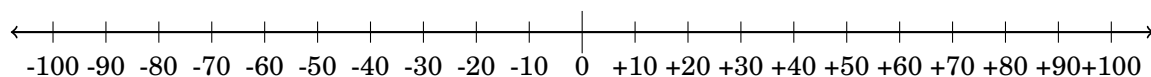
B. Processing Information

- 1. Pause if information becomes too large to absorb. Process the information already given.

2. Before you move on, make sure you understand the data given to you. Possibly translate the meaning of the text into a more easily understood form. Find a real-life example.

C. Evaluation Scale

1. To understand the strength or weakness of a choice, a negative and positive scale, such as cold and hot, like a thermometer, could help. It is similar to the scale of rational numbers, which starts with 0 in the middle.



2. Things that can be associated with this scale include the following.
 - a. “Cannot be true” or “must be false” is -100 or 100% negative.
 - b. “Has to be true” or “must be true” is +100 or 100% positive.
 - c. “Could be true” or “might be true” or “consistent with” is above +1.
 - d. “Could be false” or “might not be true” is anywhere on the scale.
 - e. “Sufficient assumption” is 100.
 - f. “Flaw” is 100.

- g. “Weaken” is 50 (or -100 to -1).
- h. “Strengthen” is +50 (or +1 to +100).
- i. Author’s emotions about something are +100, +50 < 0 > -50, -100, representing A through E.
- j. “Any” is +1 to +100.
- k. “Most” is +51 to +100.
- l. “Some” or “several” is +1 to +100.
- m. “Few” or “couple” is +2 to +49.
- n. “Many” is +1 to +99.
- o. “None” is < 0 >.
- p. “All” is +100.
- q. “Not all” is +0 to +99.
- r. “Some” versus “most” could be drawn as two-thirds of a glass filled with water or a circle with a line at two-thirds.
- s. Most of these depend on group size (cross-ref. IV.C.13, for flaw identification).

IV. Logical Reasoning

A. Passage Reading

1. Read the passage slowly, sentence by sentence. Be very critical. Question the passage. Take words at their literal meaning except for LSAT-specific language (cross-ref. III.A).

2. At the end of the sentence, ask the following questions.
3. What was said, and do you understand it?
 - a. Translate into a form you can easily understand if you did not fully understand.
 - b. If the sentence is too long or dense, split it in half or more.
4. Is this a premise or a conclusion (information or opinion)?
 - a. Grant the premises, facts, data, or information.
 - b. Deny inference, conclusion, interpretation, claim, or opinion.
 - c. In the opinion, the author is trying to convince us.
 - d. In the information, the author just gives us certain evidence.
5. Why did they say this?
6. What do you think they will say next?
7. Read the next sentence.
8. Repeat.

B. Post-Reading Analysis

1. After you have read all sentences, ask the following questions.
2. Is there a conclusion?

3. If there is a conclusion, does it have to be true given what was said and proven by the premises, or does it logically follow? Most of the conclusions will not be correct on the test.
4. If the conclusion is not proven 100% (it is too strong or contains new information), why?
5. Then ask the following.
 - a. Is there an unstated premise that is missing?
 - b. Are the subjects of evidence and conclusion linked (synonyms are okay if they are granted)?
 - c. If the subjects of evidence and conclusion are not linked, then which subjects are not linked?
 - d. Could something else make the results in the conclusion happen?
 - e. Could subjects be causing each other in reverse?
 - f. Are they repeating the main subject of premises in the conclusion to prove that conclusion?
 - g. Is the main subject necessary (only if) or sufficient (if)?
 - h. Is the sample small?
 - i. Do they attack the character (ad hominem)?
 - j. Do they attack the age of the object?
 - k. Do they refer to quantities (some, any, many, etc.)?
 - l. What is the reference group?

- m. Is that a study (data) from which conclusions were made?
 - n. Is there a wrong analogy?
 - o. Are they referring to a wrong expert?
 - p. Do they provide a false opposite?
 - q. Do they confuse certain for probable?
 - r. Do they say that something should be one way or another?
 - s. Do they mistake percentage for quantity?
 - t. Do they confuse relative and absolute?
 - u. Are they talking about the correct subject?
6. If there is no conclusion, what do you think it would be?
7. If there is a paradox or mystery that needs to be solved or explained, what would solve or explain it?
8. If this is an argument, where do the points that the authors are making intersect?

C. Question Handling

1. Read the question and ask the following questions.
2. What is the question type?
 - a. “Top-down” (do the answers have to be proven by the argument?) or “bottom-up” (do the answers, if true, have to be inferred from the premises?).

- b. “Flaw” (argument’s error; compare bottom-up). Keywords: Identifies flaw or vulnerable criticism or reasoning questionable or argument flawed or questionable strategy (see IV.C.5.i).
- c. “Strengthen” (argument is “most strongly supported” if assumed; compare bottom-up). Keywords: Most strengthen[s] or most strongly support[s] or provides most support.
- d. “Weaken” (argument fails or becomes worse; -100 to 0; compare bottom-up). Keywords: Most ... weaken[s] ... or ... most ... strongly ... weaken[s].
- e. “Parallel reasoning” or “flawed reasoning” (diagram logical statement; compare the reasoning or a flaw; bottom-up). Keywords: Most ... similar or parallels.
- f. “Must be true” or “MBT” (infer top-down; easy to prove; weakly worded; boring; obvious; has to be true). Keywords: Following must be true or conforms or illustrates or agree with or disagree with or refutes or replies by.
- g. “Most strongly supported” or “MSS” (answer is “MSS” by the passage if assumed; easy to prove; weakly worded; boring; obvious; top-down; similar to strengthen; +51 to +100; compare top-down). Keywords: Most ... strongly ... supported ... or ... provides ... most ... support.
- h. “Inference or conclusion” (has to be true given what was said; easy to prove; weakly worded; boring; obvious; abso-

lutely proven; compare top-down; +100). Keywords: Fill in the blank or ... properly ... inferred.

i. “Sufficient assumption” or “SA” (enables the conclusion; strongly worded; proves beyond doubt; compare bottom-up; +100). Keywords: Conclusion or argument ... properly ... drawn ... or ... conclusion or argument ... logically ... follows ... or ... principle ... justify ... reasoning.

j. “Necessary assumption” or “NA” (unstated premise; negation test; infer top-down). Keywords: Assumption ... argument ... depends on or requires ... or ... argument ... assumes.

k. “Paradox” (mystery; requires explanation; compare bottom-up). Keywords: Explain ... or ... reconcile.

l. “Role” (identify; “MBT”; =). Keywords: Plays ... or ... following ... or ... role.

m. “Argument” (conversation or statements of two authors; crossroads; +100). Keyword: Disagree.

3. “Principle.” If you see this word, it is usually just a variation of the above types. Just make sure the structure of the answer explicitly matches the structure of the passage.

4. What exact part or whole of the passage are they talking about?

5. What would be the answer in your opinion? Predict the answer.

6. Answer the question.

- a. Check answers one by one.
 - b. Compare to the prediction.
 - c. Refer to the passage when checking answers. Check the entire passage when you do.
 - d. Make sure you know which party the question is asking about. Is that about the author's opinion? The passage's subject belief? Someone else?
 - e. Think about real-life examples when understanding or translating the answer.
 - f. All answers are wrong except one. Be critical. Do not let answers trap you.
 - g. If this is MBT or MSS, and if they are asking you to "infer" or what is your opinion, do not react to that. They are asking you: Was this said, written, talked about, or heavily implied in the passage?
 - h. If you eliminate all answers or cannot find a good one or are not sure, just eliminate answers that are definitely wrong. Choose whatever is best out of the worst you have left.
 - i. You do not need to fully understand the answer.
7. Question answers according to type.
- a. Flaw.
 - i. Is this happening? Is this the flaw?

- ii. If there are multiple flaws, pick the most negative one (-100).
- b. Strengthen.
 - i. Does it improve the conclusion or argument?
 - ii. Does it prove the conclusion or argument? (+1 to +100).
- c. Weaken.
 - i. Does this weaken the conclusion or argument?
 - ii. Does this make the argument potentially fail, be wrong, or be a worse argument? Does it make the argument lose?
- d. Parallel reasoning or flaw.
 - i. Is this the correct flaw?
 - ii. Does this answer have the same strength?
- e. MBT.
 - i. Is this answer boring and obvious?
 - ii. Is this answer the easiest to prove and requires the least amount of assumptions? Or is it too strong or going beyond the passage?
- f. MSS.
 - i. Does this have to be true?
 - ii. Is this stronger than could be true, and either has to be true or most likely has to be true? How far does it go beyond the passage, or how strong is it?

g. Inference or conclusion.

- i. Is this the safe, boring conclusion?
- ii. Does this restate or combine premises?

h. SA.

- i. Does this make the argument or conclusion win or be 100% proven?
- ii. Is this the strongest answer?

i. NA.

- i. Does the author have to agree with it?
- ii. Is this an unstated premise, a premise that, if not true, makes an argument not exist?

j. Paradox.

- i. Is this talking about the right paradox?
- ii. Does this completely solve the mystery?

k. Role.

- i. Is this a conclusion, premise, or evidence, or something else?
- ii. Can it be used to support other parts of the passage, or do the other parts support this? Arrange sentences with the words “therefore” or “because of” to check which sentence follows from which.

l. Argument.

- i. Is this the point where things that both authors said intersect?
 - ii. Is this absolutely and 100% proven?
8. If you cannot understand the answers or cannot find the correct one, look for the answers that cannot be true and cross them out.
9. If you cannot find an answer, or have crossed out or declined all answers, start again. Eliminate all answers that cannot be true (cross-ref. III.C, for scale application).

V. Reading Comprehension

A. Passage Reading

1. Read the passage.
 - a. Read the passage slowly, sentence by sentence. Be very critical. Question the passage. Take the literal meaning of the words except for LSAT-specific words (see IV.A.1).
2. At the end of the sentence, ask the following questions.
 - a. What was said, and do you understand it?
 - b. Translate into a form you can easily understand if you did not fully understand.
 - c. If the sentence is too long or dense, split it in half or more.
 - d. Why did they say this?

- e. What do you think they will say next?
3. Read the next sentence.
4. Repeat.
5. you aim to have a dialog with the author: a conversation; a dramatic reading. Say “really?” “That’s what you think?” “Oh, I see.”

B. Passage Analysis

1. Analyze the passage.
 - a. Why is the author telling you all this? What is the point of all this?
 - b. What was the overall conclusion, if any?
 - c. What was the text about generally?
 - d. Did the author express any emotions toward anything said in the passage? If so, what were they on the $-100 -50 < 0 > +50 +100$ scale? (see III.C.1.a).
2. For comparative passages, note viewpoints and contrasts early (see II.H.6, for advanced timing).

C. Question Handling

1. Read the question and ask the following questions.

2. What is the question type?

- a. “Top-down” (do the answers have to be proven by the argument?) or “bottom-up” (do the answers, if true, have to be inferred from the premises?).
- b. “Main point” (MBT; does not have to refer to every part of the argument, but the better one or closer one wins; compare top-down). Keywords: Main ... point ... or ... overall ... meaning.
- c. “Overall summary” (MBT; does not have to refer to every part of the argument, but the better one or closer one wins; compare top-down). Keywords: Summary.
- d. “MBT” (infer top-down; easy to prove; weakly worded; boring; obvious; has to be true). Keywords: Following must be true or conforms or illustrates or agree with or disagree with or refutes or replies by.
- e. “Strengthen” (argument is “MSS” if assumed; compare bottom-up). Keywords: Most strengthen[s] or most strongly support[s] or provides most support.
- f. “MSS” (answer is “MSS” if assumed; easy to prove; weakly worded; boring; obvious; similar to strengthen; +51 to +100; compare top-down). Keywords: Most ... strongly ... supported ... or ... provides ... most ... support.
- g. “Opinion or agree or disagree” (author’s emotions; “MBT”;

compare top-down). Keywords: Author's ... opinion or feelings ... or ... agree ... with ... or ... disagree.

h. "Argument structure or role" (identify; "MBT"; =).

Keywords: Plays ... or ... following ... or ... role ... or ... structure ... or ... replies ... by.

3. What exact part or whole of the passage are they talking about?

4. What would be the answer in your opinion? Predict the answer.

5. Answer the question.

a. Check answers one by one.

b. Compare to the prediction.

c. Refer to the passage when checking answers. Check the entire paragraph.

d. Make sure you know which party the question is asking about. Is that about the author's opinion? The passage's subject belief? Someone else?

e. All answers are wrong except one. Be critical. Do not let answers trap you.

f. You do not need to fully understand the answer.

g. If this is MBT or MSS, and if they are asking you to "infer" or what is your opinion, do not react to that. They are asking you: Was this said, written, talked about, or heavily implied in the passage?

- h. If you eliminate all answers or cannot find a good one or are not sure, just eliminate answers that are definitely wrong. Choose whatever is best out of the worst you have left.
- i. If the question refers to a specific place in the passage and you are not sure exactly where, reread the whole paragraph, not just the sentence.

6. Question answers according to type.

a. Main point.

- i. What did the author want to say?
- ii. Why did the author say that?

b. Overall summary.

- i. Did the passage do this?
- ii. Are they adding anything extra?

c. MBT.

- i. Is this answer boring and obvious?
- ii. Is this answer the easiest to prove and requires the least amount of assumptions? Or is it too strong or going beyond the passage?

d. Strengthen.

- i. Does it improve the conclusion or argument?
- ii. Does it prove the conclusion or argument? (+1 to +100).

e. MSS.

- i. Does this have to be true?
 - ii. Is this stronger than could be true, and either has to be true or most likely has to be true? How far does it go beyond the passage, or how strong is it?
 - f. Opinion or agree or disagree.
 - i. Did the author express any of these emotions in the passage?
 - ii. How do they compare on the -100 -50 $< 0 > +50$ $+100$ scale?
 - g. Argument structure or role.
 - i. Is this a conclusion, premise, or evidence, or something else?
 - ii. Can it be used to support other parts of the passage, or do the other parts support this? Arrange sentences with the word “therefore” or “because of” to check which sentence follows from which (cross-ref. IV.C.7.k).
7. If you cannot understand the answers or cannot find the correct one, look for the answers that cannot be true and cross them out.
8. If you cannot find an answer, or have crossed out or declined all answers, start again. Eliminate all answers that cannot be true.

VI. Argumentative Writing Sample

A. Prompt Response

1. Read carefully.
2. Answer the presented question using the information provided.
3. Argue for one side. Provide proof that the other side will not be a good choice.

B. Structure and Analysis

1. Address your side's flaws when analyzing.
2. Two or three paragraphs are enough. One paragraph is about your choice. One argues against the other side.
3. Using the other side's perspective, make your choice clear in the opening and conclusion.

C. Final Checks

1. Make sure your grammar is good. Use a spell-checker, for example.